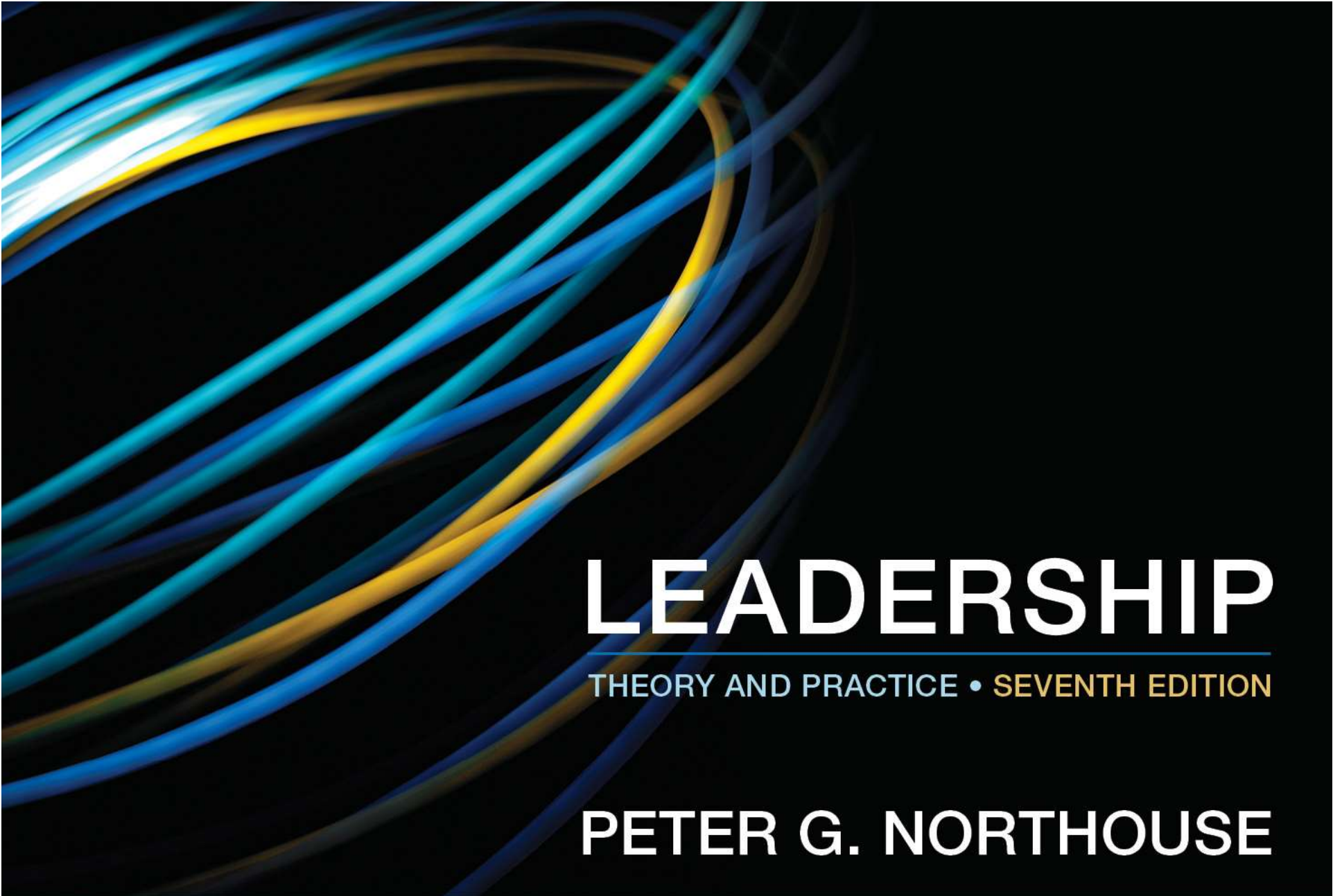




LEADERSHIP

THEORY AND PRACTICE • SEVENTH EDITION

PETER G. NORTHOUSE

Chapter 3: Skills Approach

Overview

- ✦ Skills Approach Perspective
- ✦ Three-Skill Approach (Katz, 1955)
- ✦ Skills-Based Model (Mumford et al., 2000)
- ✦ How Does the Skills Approach Work?

Skills Approach Description

Perspective

- ✦ Leader-centered perspective
- ✦ Emphasis on skills and abilities that can be learned and developed

Definition

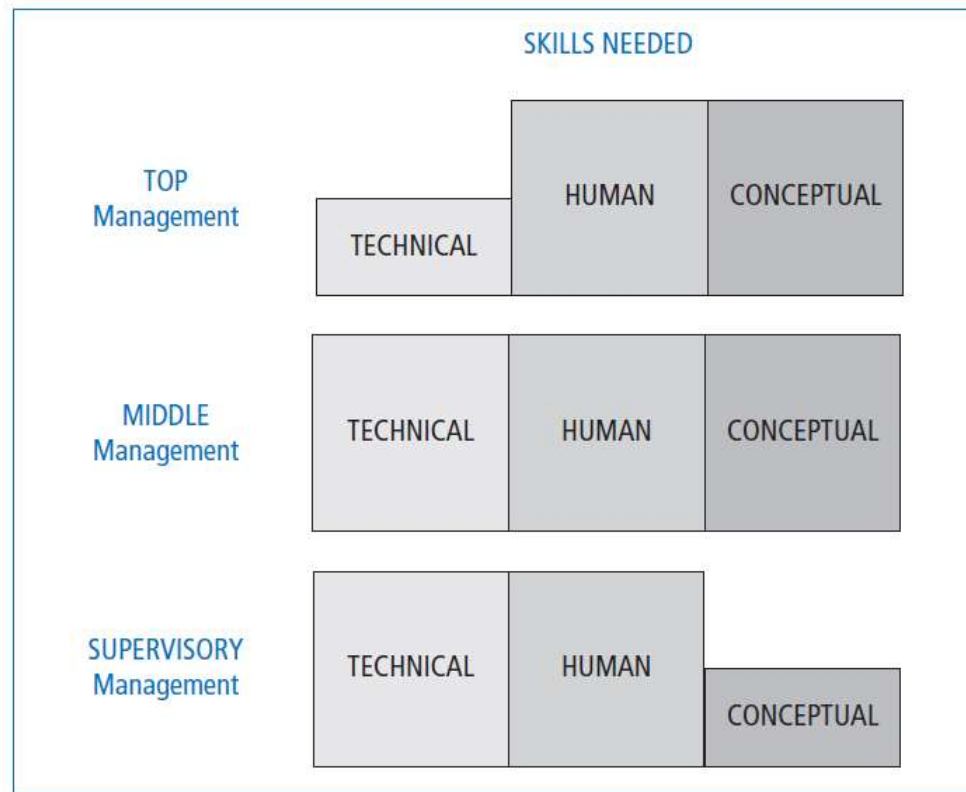
- ✦ **Leadership skills-**
The ability to use one's knowledge and competencies to accomplish a set of goals and objectives

Three-Skill Approach (Katz, 1955)

- ✦ Technical Skill
- ✦ Human Skill
- ✦ Conceptual Skill

Basic Administrative Skills – Katz (1955)

Figure 3.1 Management Skills Necessary at Various Levels of an Organization



SOURCE: Adapted from "Skills of an Effective Administrator," by R. L. Katz, 1955, *Harvard Business Review*, 33(1), pp. 33-42.

Leaders need all three skills—but relative importance changes based on level of management

Technical Skill

- ✦ Having knowledge about and being proficient in a specific type of work or activity.
 - ◆ Specialized competencies
 - ◆ Analytical ability
 - ◆ Use of appropriate tools and techniques
- ✦ Technical skills involve ***hands-on*** ability with a product or process
- ✦ Most important at ***lower*** levels of management

Human Skill

- ✦ *Having knowledge about and being able to work with people.*
 - ◆ Being aware of one's own perspective and others' perspectives at the same time
 - ◆ Assisting group members in working cooperatively to achieve common goals
 - ◆ Creating an atmosphere of trust and empowerment of members
 - ◆ Important at ***all*** levels of the organization

Conceptual Skill

- ✦ the ability to do the mental work of shaping meaning of organizational policy or issues (*what company stands for and where it's going*)
 - ◆ Works easily with ***abstraction*** and ***hypothetical notions***
 - ◆ Central to creating and articulating a ***vision*** and ***strategic plan*** for an organization
 - ◆ Most important at ***top*** management levels

Skills-Based Model

✦ **Skills Model Perspective**

✦ **Competencies**

- ◆ Individual Attributes
- ◆ Leadership Outcomes
- ◆ Career Experiences
- ◆ Environmental Influences

Skills Model Description

(Mumford, Zaccaro, Harding, Jacobs, & Fleishman, 2000)

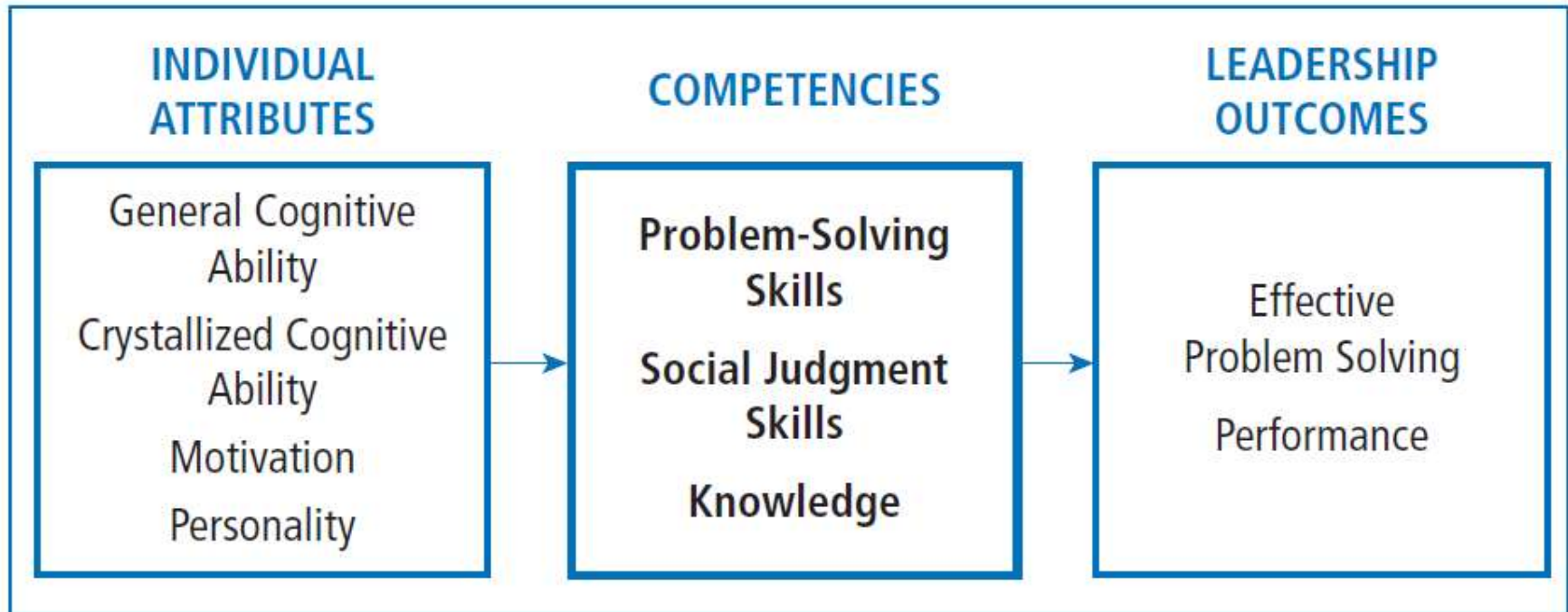
Perspective

- ✦ **Research studies (1990s)**
goal: to identify the leadership factors that create exemplary job performance in an organization
- ✦ Emphasizes the ***capabilities*** that make effective leadership possible rather than what leaders ***do***

Skills-Based Model of Leadership

- ✦ ***Capability model*** -
Examines relationship between a leader's knowledge & skills & the leader's performance.
Suggests many people have the potential for leadership

Figure 3.2 Three Components of the Skills Model



SOURCE: Adapted from "Leadership Skills for a Changing World: Solving Complex Social Problems," by M. D. Mumford, S. J. Zaccaro, F. D. Harding, T. O. Jacobs, and E. A. Fleishman, 2000, *Leadership Quarterly*, 11(1), 23.

Competencies Skills

Problem Solving

Creative ability to solve new/unusual, ill-defined organizational problems

Social Judgment

Capacity to understand people and social systems

- *Perspective taking*
- *Social perceptiveness*
- *Behavioral flexibility*
- *Social performance*

Knowledge

The accumulation of information & the mental structures to organize the information

Individual Attributes

General Cognitive Ability

Person's intelligence

- ***Perceptual processing***
- ***Information processing***
- ***General reasoning***
- ***Creative & divergent thinking***
- ***Memory***

Crystallized Cognitive Ability

Intellectual ability learned or acquired over time

Motivation

Three aspects of motivation

- ***Willingness***
- ***Dominance***
- ***-Social good***

Personality

Any characteristic that helps people cope with complex organizational situations is probably related to leader performance

Leadership Outcomes

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graph TD; A[Leadership Outcomes] --> B[Problem Solving]; A --> C[Performance]
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Problem Solving

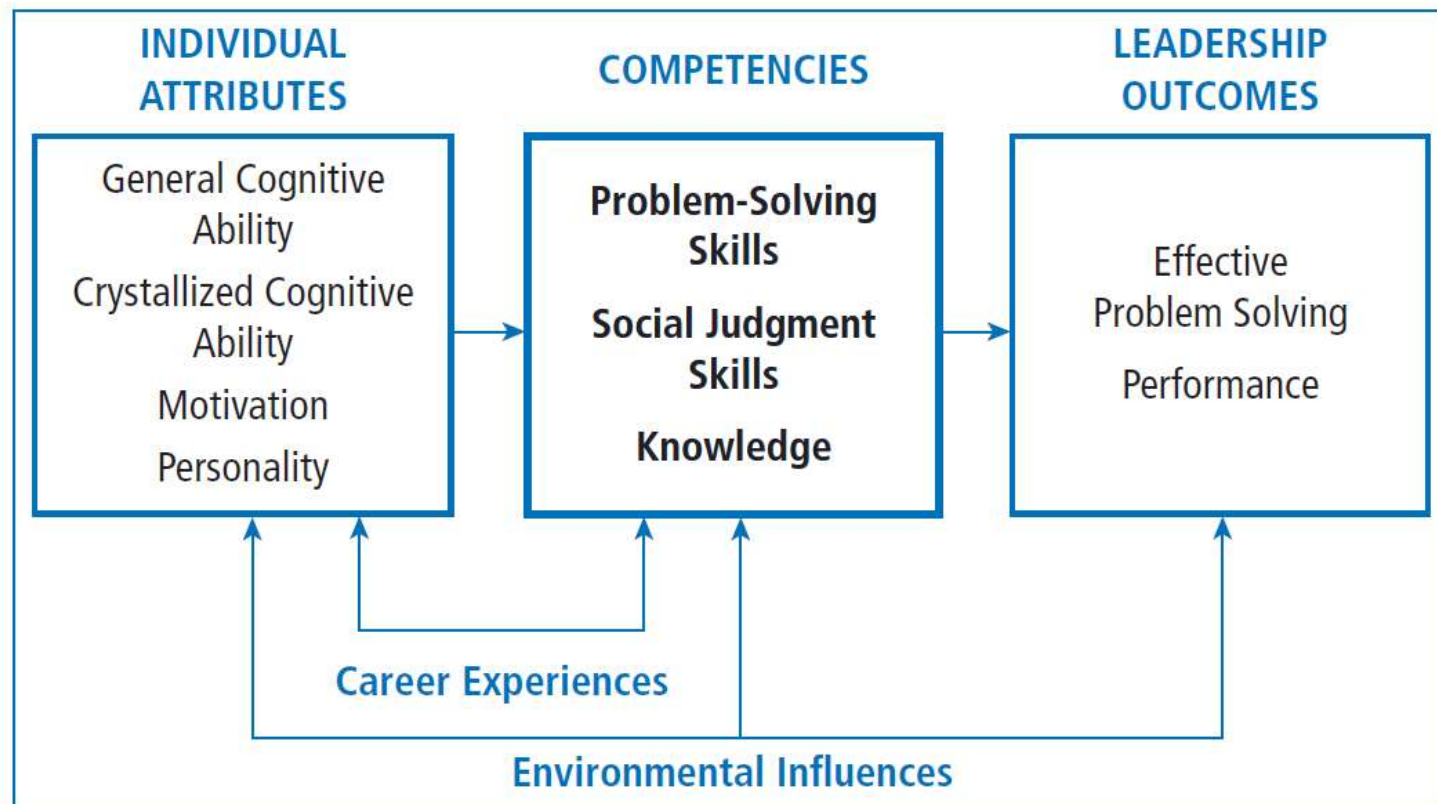
Criteria = originality & quality of solutions to problem situations – good problem solving involves creating solutions that are:

- *Logical*
- *Effective*
- *Unique*
- *Go beyond given information*

Performance

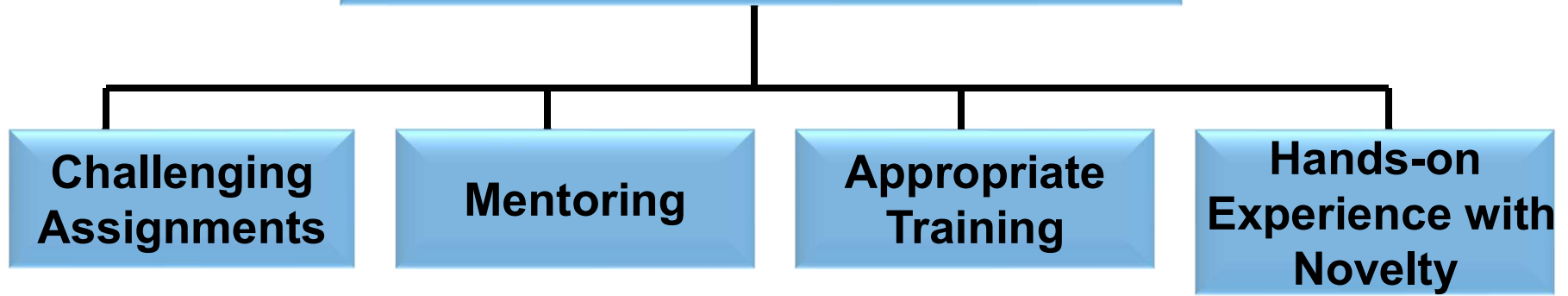
Degree to which a leader has successfully performed his/her assigned duties

Figure 3.3 Skills Model of Leadership



SOURCE: Adapted from "Leadership Skills for a Changing World: Solving Complex Social Problems," by M. D. Mumford, S. J. Zaccaro, F. D. Harding, T. O. Jacobs, and E. A. Fleishman, 2000, *Leadership Quarterly*, 11(1), 23.

Career Experiences



- ✦ Experience gained during career influences leader's knowledge & skills to solve complex problems
- ✦ Leaders learn and develop higher levels of conceptual capacity if they progressively confront more complex and long-term problems as they ascend the organizational hierarchy

Environmental Influences

- ✦ Factors in a leader's situation that lie outside of his or her competencies, characteristics, and experiences
 - **Internal** *environmental influences* – *Ex. Outdated technology, skill level of employees*
 - **External** *environmental influences* – *Ex. Economic, political, or social issues; natural disasters*

How Does the Skills Approach Work?

- ✦ Focus of Skills Approach
- ✦ Strengths
- ✦ Criticisms
- ✦ Application

Skills Approach

Focus

- ✦ Focus is primarily ***descriptive*** – it describes leadership from skills perspective
- ✦ Provides structure for understanding the nature of effective leadership

Principal Research Perspectives

- ✦ **Katz (1955)** suggests importance of particular leadership skills varies depending where leaders reside in management hierarchy
- ✦ **Mumford, Campion, & Morgeson, (2007)** suggest higher levels of all skills needed at higher levels of hierarchy
- ✦ **Mumford, Zaccaro, Harding et al. (2000)** suggest leadership outcomes are direct result of leader's skilled competency in problem solving, social judgment, & knowledge

Strengths

- ✦ First approach to conceptualize and create a ***structure*** of the process of leadership around skills
- ✦ Describing leadership in terms of skills makes leadership ***available to everyone***
- ✦ Provides an ***expansive view*** of leadership that incorporates wide variety of components (i.e., problem-solving skills, social judgment skills)
- ✦ Provides a structure ***consistent*** with leadership education programs

Criticisms

- ✦ Breadth of the skills approach appears to ***extend*** beyond the boundaries of leadership, making it more general, less precise
- ✦ Weak in predictive value; does not explain ***how*** skills lead to effective leadership performance
- ✦ Skills model includes individual attributes that are ***trait-like***

Application

- ✦ The Skills Approach provides a way to delineate the skills of a leader
- ✦ It is applicable to leaders at all levels within the organization
- ✦ The skills inventory can provide insights into the individual's leadership competencies
- ✦ Test scores allow leaders to learn about areas in which they may wish to seek further training